

GREAT IDEAS GREAT MINDS

Anuradha Joshi

Corrupt **PUBLIC OFFICIALS** should be fired, but the power to do so should vest not in politicians but an independent probing agency

Peter Evan's excellent book, *Embedded Autonomy*, starts with a popular Brazilian story about two lions who escape from a zoo. The first one runs towards the open forest, the other runs towards a group of public buildings. The first lion is soon caught and returned to the zoo. Several months later, the second lion too is caught. The first one is amazed that the second had survived in the city and evaded capture for so long. He asks the second lion how this was possible, who describes to him how he had run into a ministry and survived by eating a bureaucrat every three days and no one really seemed to notice. The first lion then asks the second lion—how was it that he was caught? Quick comes the reply: he made the mistake of eating the coffee vendor.

This little story captures the way in which public bureaucracies are perceived. Bloated, incompetent, arrogant and characterised by red tape. The more serious problem is corruption. As the unending spate of public scandals in India—the Bofors arms deal, the Bihar fodder scam, Tehelka, and most recently, the move to impeach a Kolkata High Court judge—show, inefficiency is only the tip of the iceberg. In the 2007 Transparency International's Global Corruption Perception Index, India's rank was 72 among the 179 countries. High levels of corruption have serious implications for development. There is some evidence to suggest high levels of corruption correlate with low levels of economic growth. Its impact on the poor is clearer. Corruption leads to the theft of state resources intended to benefit the poor. The failure to enforce laws protecting them makes it harder for the poor to achieve gains in the marketplace, for instance, in the case of minimum wage regulations. In its most basic form, corruption extracts a price from the poor for services.



Uncivil servants: IPS officer A.P. Mohammad Ali (in the middle), who was arrested for the misuse of official position and not taking action against the accused in the Telgi case

Increasing corruption also leads to lowering of trust in government. The World Values Survey 2005, a multi-country study of public values, shows a drop in citizen confidence in the civil services in India. But what makes public officials corrupt and inefficient? While a few might be corrupt, it is the system which creates the problem: entrenched bureaucratic structures and organisational cultures create apathetic and corrupt bureaucrats.

How can these systemic issues be tackled? There appear to be two main trends. First, policy makers in many countries are undertaking public sector reforms to improve performance and reduce corruption. Many of these reforms are based on importing private sector management practices into the public sector. For example, several countries, includ-